



was hard on them at first, shouting at the players. That was not good because they had made up their minds to pack me off. They gave negative feedback and complained to the association. I changed my approach.

The players were naive. I don't blame them. Many did not even know the names of some of our cricket greats. I had to tell them who Gary Sobers, Sunil Gavaskar and G.R. Vishwanath were. I introduced cricket culture and explained Indian cricket's history. I gained more respect when L. Balaji (former India speedster) introduced me to the players during the Buchi Babu tournament as the 'father' of centuries.

I ensured that only performers would play. They changed their approach to batting — even stepping out on the first ball. I instructed them: "No hitting the ball in the air in the

nets," and I was strict about it. But it was a lovely group. We told them we would back them, and they responded warmly. I treated them like family. I only wanted the team to win. We created a healthy environment in the dressing room. Taught them cricket language, and they improved so fast. I drilled into their system that only winning matters.

For me, it is a rebirth. I went through difficult times in my life. Cricket was lost to me. For two years, I did not step out of my house. My bank balance was zero while I fought Income Tax cases (for 10 years). I was lucky to have a public-sector job to support my family.

I found a mentor in (police inspector) Ajay Yadav, who gave me the opportunity to coach at his TNM Cricket Academy in Indirapuram in 2016. I concentrated on my coaching

Champion mindset: "We created a healthy environment in the dressing room. Taught them cricket language, and they improved so fast. I drilled into their system that only winning matters" — Ajay Sharma (right in pic).

K. MURALI KUMAR

career. Brig. Anil Gupta (administrator) and Mithun were integral to my comeback.

I would like to acknowledge the support of my family (wife Sanjana, sons Manan and Nipun, and daughter-in-law Aanchal), who have stood by me like a rock. I remember my guru, Tarak Sinha, who taught me the essence of cricket. I am happy to be the coach of a champion team. I am thankful to JKCA and Jay *bhai* for giving me a new role in cricket. I look forward to enhanced responsibilities in J&K.

(As told to Vijay Lokapally)